Gnome Venture Art Guide

Style name: Hearth Pop. Version 2, November 2026. Made with Aseprite. Clean, crisp, quirky, cute, clear.

In one line: chunky cute characters, slim well-lit objects, one thin dark outline, light from the upper left, one small odd detail in every picture.

The 10 rules

1. **Shape first.** It must read as a solid black shape at 16 px. Characters are chunky. Objects are slim, with air between parts.
2. **One outline.** 1 px dark ink all around the object. No black border, no glow. Scenery (landscapes) has no outline.
3. **Light from the upper left.** Shade on the lower right. Characters and scenes use 4 tones per colour; items use 5 to 6 so they look round and solid.
4. **Show the material.** Wood grain, shiny metal edge, waxy fruit shine, leaf veins, cloth weave, twisted thread. Dark rows where parts meet.
5. **One bright shine.** One highlight per object. Shiny things (berries, glass, metal) may have more.
6. **Colour is free.** The palette (last page) is a starting kit, not a limit. Shadows lean cool and violet, lights lean warm and yellow. Hard pixels only: no blur, no fade, no see-through pixels.
7. **Faces.** Big wide eyes. Always a designed nose: a round nose with a lit tip for people, a pointed snout with a wet nose tip for animals. Always a readable mouth.
8. **One quirk.** Each picture has one odd, charming detail: a snail on the chimney, a cat wearing a hat. Different every time.
9. **Stitching is a spice.** Gold dashed stitches only on cloth seams and hems, one seam per picture.
10. **Check small.** Look at it at 100%, 50% and 25%. Colour, eyes and shape must still read.

Items and icons 64x64



- Fill about 40 to 52 px. Handles, stems and shafts 3 to 4 px thin.
- Broken tools: same drawing plus a real gap, a chip, a splinter.
- Growth stages: same subject, one new feature each step.
- Icons are bolder and must read at 16 px.

NPC portraits 80x100





- Head and shoulders, head 38 to 44 px wide. Round backdrop disc in the villager's colour with its own thin darker outline.
- Eyes: 5x5 cream disc, 3x3 dark pupil, one glint. Do not redesign.
- Every face has a designed nose. Species must look different at a glance.
- Minor-stop villagers need one portrait per species (22 species still missing).

NPC and player models




- 3/4 top-down view: see the top of the head. 64x80 cell, feet at line 70, soft ground shadow. 2 idle frames and 4 walk frames in one strip.
- The gnome is 10 stacked layers. Hat, tunic, scarf, beard, boots and skin can each be recoloured and keep their shading. Tools: recolor.py and recolor.js.
- Dark skin tones lower the eye contrast. Keep beard and skin different colours.

Banners, regions, homes





- Draw small and scale up (region 300x200 to 1800x1200). Layers: sky, far hills, mid ground, big foreground.
- Regions are full: textured ground with a job, 3 to 5 big landmarks, 15 or more little scenes, 3 to 5 gnomes. Every jigsaw cell has its own features and at least 12 colours.
- Banners have a gold stitched hem along the bottom edge.

How a picture gets made

Step	Who	What
1	Sonnet	Writes the Lua script and the helper library.
2	Opus, pass A	Form: proportions, shape, material, colour, quirk.
3	Opus, pass B	Strong polish: re-cut the outline, remove stray pixels, push contrast. Must change a lot.
4	Review	View at 100, 50, 25% on grey and dark. Compare old and new.

Rollout order: items, portraits, models, scenes, then creatures and games. File names and sizes never change.

Checklist

- Hard pixels only, no see-through, no pure black or white
- One ink outline (not on landscapes)
- Light upper left, one shade side, one shine
- Slim shapes, material details present
- Eyes, nose, mouth readable
- One quirk
- Same size and name as the old file
- Looks different from its neighbours

Palette (starting kit)



Each row: light, base, shade, deep. Outline ink #2b1c26, paper cream #fff4d6. Making a new colour: lights turn slightly yellow and lighter, shades turn slightly violet and darker, deep goes darker still.